

Kenyan Culture and Customs

Ethnic Diversity

Kenya is home to more than 40 recognized ethnic communities, each with its own language and customs, alongside Kenyan Sign Language for the deaf community. The largest communities include the Kikuyu, Luhya, Luo, Kalenjin, Kamba, and Somali, among many others. Swahili and English serve as the country's official languages, allowing communication across this diversity, while many people also speak their community's mother tongue at home.

Hospitality

Hospitality is a strongly held value across Kenyan communities, often summarized by the word 'karibu' (welcome). Visitors, including strangers, are commonly offered food or drink, and it is considered polite to accept at least a small amount rather than refuse outright. Greeting people properly before starting a conversation, even a brief transactional one, is generally expected and skipping it can come across as abrupt.

Harambee

'Harambee', meaning 'all pull together', is a Kenyan tradition of community self-help and collective fundraising, historically used to support projects like building schools or covering medical costs for a community member. The word was adopted as Kenya's national motto after independence in 1963 and appears on the country's coat of arms, reflecting the value placed on cooperation and mutual support.

Music and Dance

Traditional music and dance vary widely by community and are often tied to specific occasions such as weddings, harvests, or rites of passage. Benga, a guitar-driven style that grew out of Luo traditional music, became one of Kenya's most influential popular music genres from the mid-20th century onward. More recently, genres like Gengetone, a Nairobi-based style blending hip-hop with local slang and rhythms, have become popular among younger audiences.

Dress and Fabric

The kitenge (also called ankara in some other African countries) is a brightly patterned cotton fabric widely used for clothing, especially at celebrations and cultural events. Along the coast, influenced by Swahili and Arab culture, the kanga, a lighter printed cloth often bearing a printed Swahili proverb, is commonly worn and also given as a gift.